

IT'S HIS TURN

The country's highest wicket-taker is made Test captain and the leadership of the Indian team is split for the first time. Can an old warrior keep the peace?



THE VETERAN:
Kumble

■ By Sharda Ugra

After his return to international cricket from surgery in late 2001, Anil Kumble began to share a running joke with John Wright, then the India coach. As his shoulder and career regained strength, the coach told Kumble he needed to think like a president seeking longer terms in office. "Four more years," Wright would say, echoing the chanting of election rallies, "four more years" and Kumble would have to grin. Four more years.

Four more years from then to now, and Indian cricket's quietest achiever is the 30th Test captain of India, leading the team into a three-Test series against Pakistan starting next week.

The morning after he was named captain, as noise and smoke from Diwali firecrackers settled over Bangalore, Kumble and Wright laughed down a phone line again. The New Zealander told INDIA TODAY, "When I started working in India, I really couldn't understand why Anil had not had the opportunity to lead earlier. But it's funny how things work out."

What's been happening with Indian captaincy, though, is most certainly not funny. By the time the captaincy got to Kumble, via Rahul Dravid's abdication and Sachin Tendulkar's 'thanks-but-no-thanks', it looked as if the job on offer was not the one almost all cricketers secretly aspire to, but a tour of duty on Siachen.

Then, India's most overtly glacial cricketer and its highest wicket-taker acquiesced, to the relief of sweating officials and selectors. Kumble, 37, may have been formally given the charge only for the series against